

growth for the sake of growth. It's crucial to focus on the central injustices that we've been witnessing: child undernourishment, lack of medical care, premature privatisation of health care, and lack of education. These are failures of the state. In Kerala, more than 50 per cent of the health care is provided privately, but that is on the secure basis of public health care being available for all.

I have nothing against the private sector when it comes with the solid basis of public health care being available for all. But since in most of the country it is not, what you get is a kind of substitute private health care which leads to the exploitation of peasants who know little about their illnesses, but know the symptoms. They don't know whether they are getting the right treatment and when they can't get medical care from the state sector, they spend a lot of money obtaining relief from the private sector where they are often exploited. Once I complained about the combination of quackery and crookery, and I think something of that still exists. Similarly, in education too, if state schools were better financed, better run, if there were

nate gender inequality, maternal undernourishment. These are essentially the real problems. We have such a widespread incidence of maternal undernourishment that in turn leads to foetal undernourishment and underweight babies, child undernourishment and their inability to grow into healthy boys and girls. There is deprivation after you are born too, but a lot of it goes back to the womb. And that goes back to gender inequality. So gender deprivation, gender inequality and child deprivation are very closely related. And now we have the medical argument that undernourished babies tend to develop more cardiovascular diseases. Undernourishment of mothers, undernourished babies and high incidence of cardiovascular diseases in India are interconnected where the neglect of women plays a central part.

We ought to look at what the big failures are, and enter into a debate and ask the question: if you could eliminate one injustice, which one would it be? There's nothing to prevent the elimination of one injustice being combined with the elimination of other injustices. So the big question is: what are the big injustices? We

Only 10 per cent of the Indian population has health insurance. The sector is projected to grow to \$5.75 billion by 2010.

65 years

is expected to be the life expectancy in India by 2020, compared to 69 years in upper middle income countries such as Hungary, Argentina, Chile, Malaysia, Mexico and South Africa.

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greater accountability, greater resources, there could be a much better use of the state sector and much less need for private education. I think the premature privatisation of the education and health sector has the effect of generating both inefficiency and inequality. Sometimes people spend the little income they have on medical care which they can scarcely afford. If we generate more public resources and use them with a better identification of the prevailing injustices in India, we could make a big change.

I used to get frustrated with the Indian economy: it had the potential of a high growth rate but it never seemed to grow. And I never, for a second, thought this was a result of democracy because I think economic growth depends upon the friendliness of the economic climate and not on the fierceness of the prevailing political arrangement, which, to a great extent, we have achieved. But there are other things that we can do. It is very shocking that we have not done more on the right to food for everyone, including children. We have not done more to elimi-

have paid little attention to the big constructive things we could have done to eliminate gender inequality, to eliminate undernourishment of children and also the class divisions. We have taken a reasonable number of initiatives on caste. The question is whether they have been adequately well-directed and well-thought-out to make them effective. In my book *The Idea of Justice*, I've tried to make a distinction again and again between *neeti* and *nyaya*. *Neeti* is about appropriate rules and institutions and *nyaya* is the realisation. I think that caste policy has been driven by *neeti*: certain reservation of this kind and reservation of that kind and so on. We need a more *nyaya*-based perspective in dealing with caste distinctions in India. The focus does relate to a deficiency in Indian political thinking on this matter, mainly over concentration on *neeti* compared to *nyaya*. What kind of *neeti* you need is still an open question.

Perfect justice is very hard to come by and indeed very hard to agree on what it might be